Tenth standard had been one of my best in school. I had made some of my most wonderful friends in that class. It was an age when friends mattered more than family. Our old-fashioned bungalow in Babina, Uttar Pradesh, where Papaji had been posted, would mostly be bustling with my friends coming and leaving every now and then. This would keep Maa busy in the kitchen as she would try to tend to the demands of each friend. The only respite for her were on Thursdays and Saturdays, when my friends and I would go to watch movies at an auditorium inside the cantonment. My scooter-riding lessons also began in the tenth standard. Papaji would take me out on his scooter after dinner every day, since the roads inside the cantonment would generally be empty then. But there came a time when I started making excuses to avoid learning how to ride the scooter. My friend, Navneet, had told me that I had ruined my hair by wearing the helmet every day and the other girls had started noticing it too. It wasn't as fluffy as before, I was told. So I refrained from going with Papaji after a few days. But he wouldn't listen. At times he would take me for these riding lessons against my will. This business of learning how to ride a scooter wasn't left unfinished. Consequently, I got my learner's licence. The bright side was that I could go out on the scooter with my friends. But I would take the helmet off after I would be out of Papaji's watchful gaze. The hair was a priority at that age, more than safety. Papaji's instructions to always wear a helmet were ignored.

One fine Sunday in April, Navneet and I decided to drive to Sukma Dukma Dam, which was also a famous tourist destination. It was a breezy day and staying indoors would have been a crime. I called her to my place. Maa packed us some sandwiches and pakoras that we could enjoy on the reservoir's shores. We were set to leave by eleven.

'Don't forget the helmets . . . one for the pillion rider too,' Papaji reminded us as he heard me kick-start the scooter. He was sitting in the lawn with his face buried in a newspaper.

'Sure, Papaji,' I replied as I passed the helmet to Navneet, who shook her head in disapproval. 'Only until we get out of here,' I whispered to Navneet, and she took the helmet reluctantly.